That was when I started getting nervous, looking around at the people we'd invited, some of whom I'd never even said hello to before. I knew I was down to make my first speech since our wedding day. I was England captain and all these people had come to my home. I couldn't get out of it, could I? I knew where I wanted to lead up to: giving Victoria a present to thank her for making the evening happen. But before that? Well, there were other thank yous and then something about UNICEF, the United Nations childrens' charity with which Manchester United were involved. I knew I should say something about the NSPCC and the abused children we were raising money for. I was so worried about leaving something or somebody out, I had it all written down on little index cards. Eventually I got onto something more personal and I was able to put the cards down. Not long before, I'd visited a kids' shelter down in South London. I sat in a room in front of a couple of dozen of these youngsters who all had terrible stories to tell. You could feel something like hostility in the air: not towards me, particularly, but towards the whole world. They were kids with chips on their shoulders and I wondered, at first, whether this had been a good thing to agree to do. The questions were absolutely direct:

'How's Posh, then?'

'What cars have you got?'

'How much money do you earn?'

They weren't worried about how the staff or me or anyone else might react. I knew I couldn't say I didn't want to answer their questions. They'd all lived through things that I'm lucky I'd never had to face: rape, prostitution, drugs, time in jail. A few answers from me were the least they deserved. The grown-ups were looking at me to see what I wanted to do.

'It's fine. I don't need to check the questions first. Let them ask what they want.'

That afternoon turned into one of the most rewarding things I've ever done away from soccer. Obviously there weren't any press there: this was just me and the kids talking. I relaxed. They did too. After a while, I think we decided we liked each other and ended up laughing and joking: about soccer, about my life, about nothing in particular. My defenses came down and, during that time, so did theirs. I couldn't change anything that had happened to them but it made a difference to me that at least we were able to connect with each other. By the way they acted towards me, it seemed that made a difference to them too. Maybe telling the story of my afternoon at the kids'